

Throwing light on the other areas in which Aviva has implemented FOSS tools, Harnath Babu quips, "We have deployed a mobility application that has been developed on HTML5 and we use PhoneGap, an open source framework that allows you to create mobile apps. To strengthen our online platform for sale of insurance, we use Red Hat JBoss BRMS, which brings in rule based automated underwriting and rule based premium calculation capabilities. It also provides for a Web-based authoring environment for business users to contribute to the design and development of business decision management applications. We also use Rabbit MQ, a highly reliable enterprise messaging system for branch documents scanning application. We use WordPress for our Intranet, which serves almost 4,000 people."

The list is endless. Our online services are being sold on the open source stack, but the database that these are running on is Oracle. We are evaluating the possibility of moving to EnterpriseDB or PostgreSQL, he says.

He goes on to add that the company was able to save almost 80 per cent on IT costs by implementing various FOSS tools at Aviva India.

Addressing the perceptions about FOSS

It was not easy for Harnath Babu to convince the management and his internal team to go for the open source model and this posed a major challenge. "The maturity to understand the concept of open source is still not there in India, and even it was difficult to convince management and my team for taking the open source route. It was important to remove that mental block first. The best way to convince them was to show them various industry feedbacks and successful cases of the open source business model. I showed them examples of how open source can help you optimise your budget. After a slew of meetings, I was finally able to convince my team. The second challenge was to find the right kind of partner or vendor. But once we came across right partners and support options from Red Hat, all our issues were addressed," says Harnath Babu.

Not many know that Hamath Babu has been promoting open source since the last nine years. He has a word of advice for companies looking to go the open source way. "It is important to understand the benefits that open source brings, and one needs to broaden one's outlook for the same. Choosing a good partner or vendor can help you scale the heights of success. It is also advisable to use standard open source software in the case of large organisations," he says. 

By Priyanka Sarkar

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